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The web of kinship among the Tallensi

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A father's sister is, in short, a kind of female 'father', but without the jural and ritual attributes of fatherhood. A father's sister must be treated with respect. It would be grossly improper, for example, to joke with her as one jokes with a wife's sister; and to strike or abuse her, even if she were much younger than oneself, would be a sin. But the respect accorded to her is only a pale reflection of the attitude implicit in filial piety. It is much more a matter of etiquette than of emotion, as if it were merely conventional and not evoked by a feeling of moral obligation.

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A marked characteristic of a person's relations with his or her father's sister is the absence of specific mutual obligations. Just as a *ba-p(ɔ)k* has in reality no rights over her brother's children, so she has no specific duties of either a ritual or a secular kind towards them, or they to her. This is the chief contrast between this relationship and that of parent and child or that of mother's brother and sister's child. Only a shadow of a ritual sanction comes into the relationship, in the form of the belief that the curse of a *ba-p(ɔ)k* can harm her brother's child, and in the notion that she stands under the protection of the same ancestors as the latter. Hence, though she cannot demand services from her brother's child, it is felt that a request for help from her should be met, even at the cost of some inconvenience. If a person offends his father's sister and she reproaches him saying, 'I bore you (identifying herself with her brother) and this is how you treat me. My ancestors have seen it, my fathers have seen it (*Man d(ɔ) i la k-i ɔŋ(ə)m la ŋwala; n-yaanam nyeya, m-banam nyeya*)', this has the force of a curse because she is invoking her ancestors who are also his ancestors. Such a curse would disturb a native, but not nearly so deeply as a father's curse or if a mother's brother refused to sacrifice on his behalf.

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Because their relationship is devoid of a definite jural coefficient and is not subject to organized ritual sanctions; because, also, a father's sister stands outside the scheme of economic and domestic associations in which the relationship of parent and child is set, the relations of father's sister and brother's child are free of the undercurrent of tension found in those of father and child. A woman's bonds with her brother's children are fundamentally bonds of sentiment. That is why they seldom endure beyond one generation, or extend beyond the nuclear lineage.

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The personal relations of father's sister and brother's child have much  335 in common with those of mother's brother and sister's child. They are similarly influenced by the closeness of the sibling tie between the brother and the sister, as is to be expected. There is this difference, however, that the contacts between *ba-p(ɔ)k* and brother's child are chiefly maintained by the *ba-p(ɔ)k*'s visits to her parental home, and not by the brother's child's being taken, or going on visits to her. They are largely a by-product of the woman's contacts with her parental home, and they diminish as she grows older. A man has no occasion to visit his *ba-p(ɔ)k* regularly, and a woman is apt to do so only if she lives near her. Opportunity and disposition count for more than in the personal relations of true mother's brother and sister's child. Thus a *ba-p(ɔ)k* sometimes has a brother's child to live with her, but this is rarer than for children to stay with an *ah(ə)b*, and there is usually a utilitarian motive on the side of the *ba-p(ɔ)k*. (ɔ)mara's sister had their late brother's two sons staying with her for two or three years each, in succession. She had them to stay with her so that they could look after her son's horse, and they went home again as soon as they were big enough to farm. If a girl stays with a *ba-p(ɔ)k* it is almost always as a nursemaid to her baby. A boy does not go to live with a *ba-p(ɔ)k* and grow up in her household, as he might with an *ah(ə)b*. There is an obvious reason for all this. A *ba-p(ɔ)k* does not 'own' her household as an *ah(ə)b* does. She cannot have her brother's child living with her except with her husband's consent; and though he would, out of consideration for her, not withhold his consent, he might demur against the burden of supporting another man's child, who is no kin of his, for a long time. A woman cannot give her brother's son a place in the household economy as an *ah(ə)b* can to his sister's son.

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